Bridge to Terabithia (The Book)

By Katherine Paterson

Suggested Roles: ***ACTOR:*** *Jesse, Narrator 2, Leslie's Father*
ACTRESS: *Narrator 1, Leslie, May Belle, Jesse's Father*

NOTE: This cutting asks each student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

JESSE: **(Pg 2)** *(while running)* I get up early every day to run. I figure if I work at it, I could be the fastest runner in the fifth grade when school opens up. I have to be the fastest. . . not one of the fastest or next to the fastest, but ***the*** fastest. The very best. **(Pg 20)** Watch out Wayne Pettis. . . I'll get you. You can't beat me.

NARRATOR 1: **(Pg 5)** Wayne Pettis would be in the sixth grade with the rest of the big guys. [But] anybody had a chance to be the fastest runner, and by Miss Bessie, this year it was going to be Jesse Oliver Aarons, Jr.!

INTRODUCTION

ACTOR: *Jesse Aaron's greatest ambition is to be the fastest runner in the fifth grade.*
ACTRESS: *But on the first day of school, a new kid, a* ***girl,*** *boldly crosses over to the boy's side of the playground and outruns everyone.*
ACTOR: *That's not a very promising beginning for a friendship, but Jesse Aarons and Leslie Burke become inseparable.*
ACTRESS: *It doesn't matter to Jesse that Leslie dresses funny, or that her family has a lot of money -- but no TV. Leslie has imagination and she is fearless!*
ACTOR: *For Jesse, who is afraid of everything . . . Leslie was everything he wanted to be.*
ACTOR: *Together, they create Terabithia, a magical kingdom in the woods where they reign and the only limits are their imaginations.*
TOGETHER: *Bridge to Terabithia by Katherine Paterson*

LESLIE: **(Pg 49-50)** Do you know what we need? We need a place. . . just for us. It might be a whole secret country and you and I would be the rulers of it.

JESSE: Ok. . . Where would we have it?

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LESLIE: Over there in the woods where nobody would come and mess it up. *(getting excited)* I know. . . it could be a magic country like Narnia, and the only way you can get in is by swinging across on this enchanted rope. Come on. . . let's find a place to build our castle stronghold. . . *(searching)* How about right here?

JESSE: **(Pg 51)** *(nodding vigorously and catching Leslie's excitement)* Sure! This will be a good place to build. . .

NARRATOR 2: Leslie named their secret land "Terabithia," and she loaned Jess all of her books about Narnia, so he would know how things went in a magic kingdom.

LESLIE: **(Pg 52)** You should draw a picture of Terabithia for us to hang in the castle.

JESSE: *(gazing in wonder at their surroundings) I* can't . . . I just can't get the poetry of the trees.

LESLIE: Don't worry. You will someday!

NARRATOR 2: He believed her because, there in the shadowy light of the stronghold, everything seemed possible. They owned the world and no enemy could ever defeat them.

JESSE: **(Pg 60)** I used to think this place was haunted.

LESLIE: Oh, it is. But you don't have to be scared. It's not haunted with evil things.

JESSE: How do you know?

LESLIE: You can just feel it. Listen. *(they close their eyes, then Leslie continues solemnly)* This is not an ordinary place. Even the rulers of Terabithia come into it only at times of greatest sorrow or of greatest joy. We must strive to keep it sacred. It would not do to disturb the Spirits.

*****Scene change *****

LESLIE: **(Pg 103)** I've never been to a church before . . . do you think your parents would let me go with you?

JESSE: You'd hate it. It's boring *(then skeptically)* You can't wear pants

LESLIE: *(indignantly)* I've got some dresses, Jess Aarons!

TOGETHER: *(holding a hymn book; they sing a few lines – pick your favorite hymn (Jesse is bored; Leslie is enthralled)*

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LESLIE: **(Pg 107-109)** *(after church)* I'm really glad I came. *(Jess looks at Leslie in unbelief)* It was better than a movie!

JESSE: You're kidding.

LESLIE: No, I'm not. That whole Jesus thing is really interesting isn't it? All those people wanting to kill him when he hadn't done anything to hurt them. It's really kind of a beautiful story – like Aslan.

MAY BELLE: It ain't beautiful. It's scary, nailing holes right through somebody's hand.

JESSE: May Belle's right. It's because we're all vile sinners God made Jesus die.

LESLIE: Do you think that's true?

JESSE: It's in the Bible, Leslie.

LESLIE: *(looks like she's going to argue, then shakes her head)* It's crazy isn't it? You ***have*** to believe it, but you hate it. I ***don't*** have to believe it and I think it's beautiful.

MAY BELLE: You gotta believe the Bible, Leslie.

LESLIE: *(a genuine question)* Why?

MAY BELLE: *(eyes huge)* 'Cause if you don't believe the Bible, God'll damn you to hell when you die.

LESLIE: I don't believe it. *(turns to Jesse)* I don't even think you've ***read*** the Bible.

JESSE: I've read most of it. *(grinning)* S'bout the only book we got around our place.

LESLIE: OK, but I still don't think God goes around damning people to hell.

MAY BELLE: But Leslie. . . What if you ***die***? What's going to happen to you?

******Scene change ******

NARRATOR 2: **(Pg 110)** On Easter Monday, the rain began in earnest. **(Pg 112)** When they got to the bank of the creek, they stopped.

NARRATOR 1: It was an awesome sight. Like in *The Ten Commandments* on TV when the water came rushing into the dry path Moses had made and swept all the Egyptians away . . .

NARRATOR 2: The creek was a roaring eight-foot-wide sea, sweeping before it great branches and logs swirling them about like Egyptian chariots, the hungry waters sometimes leaping

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the banks, daring them to try to confine it. **(Pg 115-118)** For Jess the fear of crossing rose with the height of the creek [but] Leslie never seemed to hesitate.

LESLIE: *(playing the role of Queen of Terabithia)* Dost know what is in my mind, O King? Methinks some evil being has put a curse on our beloved kingdom.

JESSE: Damn weather bureau.

LESLIE: *(not wanting to kid)* Let us go into the sacred grove and inquire of the Spirits what this evil might be and how we must combat it. For I perceive that this is no ordinary rain that is falling upon our kingdom. *(lifting her arms and face toward the green canopy above)* O, Spirits of the grove, we come on behalf of our beloved kingdom which lies even now under the spell of some evil, unknown force. Give us, we beseech thee, wisdom to discern this evil, and power to overcome it.

JESSE: *(also raising his arms)* Um. Uh. Um. Yes. Please listen, thou Spirits.

******Scene change ******

NARRATOR 1: **(Pg 119)** It had seemed to Jess when he went to bed Wednesday night that he could relax, that everything was going to be all right, but he awoke in the middle of the night with the horrible realization that it was still raining.

NARRATOR 2: He would have to tell Leslie that he wouldn't go to Terabithia. He was obviously not worthy to be king of Terabithia. It wasn't so much that he minded telling Leslie that he was afraid to go; it was that he minded being afraid.

NARRATOR 1: **(Pg 118)** He was obviously not worthy to be king of Terabithia. Whoever heard of a king who was scared of tall trees and a little bit of water?

JESSE: *(to himself)* All I gotta do is say, "Leslie, I don't wanta go over there today." Just like that. Easy as Pie.

NARRATOR 1: **(Pg 119)** He hardly slept the rest of the night, listening to the horrid rain and knowing that no matter how high the creek came, Leslie would still want to cross it.

******Scene change ******

NARRATOR 2: **(Pg 130)** He was all the way into the kitchen before he realized something was wrong.

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JESSE'S FATHER: (Pg 131-132) *(quietly)* I'm real sorry, boy. They found the Burke girl this morning down in the creek.

JESSE: No. Leslie wouldn't drown. She could swim real good.

JESSE'S FATHER: That old rope you kids been swinging on broke.

JESSE: *(shaking his head)* No. No! I don't believe you. You're lying to me!

MAY BELLE: *(echoing)* But, Leslie, what if you die?

JESSE: *(looking about wildly)* No. It's a lie. Leslie ain't dead.

JESSE'S FATHER: They think she musta hit her head on something when she fell. I'm really sorry, son. *(Jesse begins to cry)* **(Pg 139)** Your mother and I thought we ought to go down to the neighbors and pay respects. *(clears his throat)* I think it would be fitting for you to come, too. Seeing's you was the one that really knowed the little girl.

JESSE: *(talks to Leslie in his mind) You know something weird?*

LESLIE: *What?*

JESSE: *I was scared to come to Terabithia this morning. (angrily) You think it's so great to die and make everyone cry and carry on. Well, it ain't.*

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NARRATOR 1: (Pg 144-146) He heard his father ask quietly over his head about "the service."

LESLIE'S FATHER: [We] decided to have the body cremated and are going to take the ashes to the family home in Pennsylvania tomorrow.

NARRATOR 1: ***Cremated***. Something clicked inside Jess's head. That meant Leslie was gone. Turned to ashes. He would never see her again. Not even dead. Never. How could they dare? Leslie belonged to him. More to him than anyone in the world. No one had even asked him.

JESSE: *(anguished, to the audience)* I was the only one who really cared for Leslie. But she went and died just when I needed her the most. She went and left me. She went swinging on that rope just to show me that she was no coward.

LESLIE: *(laughing) So there, Jess Aarons!*

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JESSE: *(sadly)* She tricked me. She made me leave my old self behind and come into her world, and then before I was really at home in it but too late to go back, she left me stranded there -- like an astronaut wandering about the moon. Alone.

NARRATOR 1: He was never sure just when he left, but he remembered running up the hill to his own house with angry tears streaming down his face. He raced into his bedroom and retrieved the papers and paint that Leslie had given him at Christmastime.

NARRATOR 2: He ran out the kitchen door and down to the stream without looking back. Above the crab apple tree, the frayed end of the rope swung gently.

LESLIE: **(Pg 60)** *(echoing) Even the rulers of Terabithia come only at times of greatest sorrow or of greatest joy. . .*

JESSE: **(Pg 146-147)** *(screaming something without words, he flings the papers and paints into the water)*

NARRATOR 2: There was nowhere to go. Nowhere. Ever again.

JESSE'S FATHER: *(who had followed Jesse)* That was a damn fool thing to do.

JESSE: *(crying hard, barely able to breathe)* I don't care! I don't care! I hate her. I wish I'd never seen her in my whole life.

JESSE'S FATHER: *(pulling him close, comforting)* There. There. Sssh. . . Hell ain't it?

JESSE: Do you believe people go to hell, really go to hell, I mean?

JESSE'S FATHER: Lord, boy, don't be a fool. God ain't gonna send any little girls to hell.

JESSE: *(softly)* She wouldn't have been eleven until November. . .

******The next day ******

NARRATOR 1: **(Pg 150)** He woke up Saturday morning with a dull headache. **(Pg 160)** Before Leslie came, he had been a nothing – a stupid, weird little kid trying to act big – trying to hide a whole mob of foolish little fears.

NARRATOR 2: It was Leslie who had taken him into Terabithia and turned him into a king. [He felt called to Terabithia] **(Pg 151-152)** If was still Terabithia . . .

NARRATOR 1: The castle stronghold was dark and damp, but there was no evidence there to suggest that the queen had died. He felt the need to do something fitting. But Leslie was

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not there to tell him what it was. The anger which had possessed him yesterday flared up again.

JESSE: Leslie, I'm just a dumb dodo and you know it. What am I supposed to do? *(his voice catches)* Leslie, were you scared? Did you know you were dying? Were you scared like me?

NARRATOR 1: A picture of Leslie being sucked into the cold water flashed across his brain. **(Pg 160-161)** She wasn't there. . . It was up to him to pay back the world in beauty and caring what Leslie had loaned him.

JESSE: *(takes a deep breath)* Well, you just have to stand up to your fear and not let it squeeze you white. Right, Leslie?

LESLIE: *Right.*

JESSE: **(Pg 152-153)** *(a sudden idea)* A funeral wreath for the queen…

NARRATOR 1: He sat in the clear space between the bank and the first line of trees and bent a pine bough into a circle, tying it with a piece of wet string from the castle. He picked spring beauties from the forest floor and wove them among the needles.

JESSE: *(reverently he kneels and offers up the wreath to the Spirts)* Father, into Thy hands I commend her spirit.

NARRATOR 1: Leslie would have liked those words. They had the ring of the sacred grove - - the grove in Terabithia.

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AWARD HISTORY

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